CHAPTER FOUR

Making Love to the Spirit

Sex and Dreams in Spiritual Marriages

In July 2015, I spent my nights sleeping in the master bedroom in Manbo Maude's home in Jacmel, among the barrels of ritual clothes she kept stored next to the bed. Some of the clothes were from past ceremonies, and some she kept for other practitioners for upcoming events. There were packages of food and water along the wall, and under the bed were baskets filled with sacred *koulie* or "beads," *moushwa* or "scarves," and *ason* or "sacred rattles" for initiation rituals and ceremonies. I shared the room with a practitioner and people came in and out all day and night to grab clothes or food, take naps, or gossip with one another. One of the ceremonies Manbo Maude and her practitioners were preparing for was a spiritual marriage for an initiate named Zeta who had moved to a different Vodou home but was excitedly preparing for the marriage being performed in Manbo Maude's temple. Zeta is a cisgender, heterosexual Black American woman in her mid-thirties with a heavy southern accent, whose ancestry is rooted in Louisiana and Texas. Zeta's marriage was one of the first spiritual marriages that I witnessed in Jacmel. She married seven male spirits, including Kouzen, the spirit of agriculture. Spiritual marriages take months and possibly years to prepare for, but because of her specific circumstances, Zeta had only three months to obtain the needed clothes and undergo the required ritual preparation.[1] After the ceremony, she shared with me the experience of getting married:

> It was all going so fast! So it was like a blur. People had to zip me up on the back and throw me back out to get married to spirits. I had so many costume changes I felt like a model! Overall, it was a good feeling. I couldn't see how I looked like because there was no mirror. The spirit was waiting for me, and people were rushing me back downstairs. Although I had no mirror, I could see the spirits face looking back at me and he [Kouzen] was smiling. And he commented on how good I looked. You can see it on his face. [The spirits] look you over. They are excited to see you. Although I felt flushed, they were happy. And that's all that matters.[2]

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Manbos flaunting wedding rings that represent their marriages to male spirits in Mattapan, March 2021 (photo by Eziaku Nwokocha).

Without a mirror, Zeta is unable to see her own reflection, yet the audience and Kouzen affirm her appearance through their approval. Their "sacred gaze," conveyed through the social experience of the ceremony, reflects the ritual validity of her outfit in service of her marriage.[3] Kouzen's gaze and his pleased smile confirm the effectiveness of Zeta's sartorial efforts and her worthiness as a spouse. The gazes of the audience and the spirits confer on Zeta's marriage the necessary religious authenticity, cementing her connection to

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Kouzen. This ritual reality illustrates spiritual vogue, emphasizing the multiple dimensions of sight and its importance to Vodou ceremonies. Zeta dresses for the *lwa* and the audience, incorporating her African Diasporic identity as a southern Black American in Haitian Vodou; in turn, the spirits and the audience offer their approval after witnessing her ritual performance and her garments. As a result, she is able to publicly declare her affinity for the spirits and continue asking for their favor, honoring them in many ceremonies to come.

In her marriage ceremony Zeta donned a two-piece outfit for Kouzen, standing tall inside the temple awaiting the spirit's arrival. Her light-blue denim blouse was plaid, with a prominent ruffle that flowed down to form a wide boat-neck collar. White cotton trim accentuated the ends of her sleeves and blouse. The plaid cotton and denim were arranged in a checkered pattern on her blouse, which reached her mid-thigh. The cotton skirt underneath was long enough to brush along the dirt floor: it had a gradual overlay of flounces in midnight blue emerging after the abrupt stop of the blouse's patchwork pattern. She also wore a layered necklace with four strings of pearls, a bracelet made of three rows of pearls, and large pearl earrings in tribute to her heritage as a "southern belle."[4] "He's country, like me!"[5] Zeta explained, associating Kouzen's country or agricultural identity with her southern heritage. Kouzen reflected pieces of her own heritage, representing the embrace of her ancestral connection to the land. The spirit's visual and cultural significance to Zeta's familial past echoed his clear link to a similar past in Haiti, where millions of enslaved Africans toiled on plantations. By claiming Kouzen's history as her own, Zeta instinctively created this Diasporic connection.

Zeta described the denim fabric of her dress as hot and heavy.[6] Her dress cut a bigger profile than most in the room: it had more fabric, more ruffles, and more layers, all to accentuate her status as a Manbo and to emphasize that this was her wedding day: it was her time to shine.

Manbo Maude and other practitioners sang Vodou songs to call Kouzen and welcome him into the ceremony. Kouzen arrived and mounted a Haitian female initiate. Practitioners loosely tied a royal blue moushwa around her neck and handed her a straw satchel. When Kouzen looked at Zeta, he was overjoyed and gave her a kiss on the cheek, inspecting the ring on her finger, which was a silver band with a red jewel imbedded into it. Zeta had the ring made for her marriage to Kouzen. He smiled and kissed her hand multiple times, embracing her in appreciation. Zeta and Kouzen took each other's hands and walked to the altar, where a *prèt savann* or "bush priest" in

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Haitian Kreyòl, and several witnesses awaited.[7] As a prèt savann, the priest is not ordained by the Catholic Church, yet he sometimes dons the vestments of an actual priest and usually wears a cross around his neck. Though prèt savanns are not ordained, they still have religious responsibilities during the weddings, such as officiating the event and repeating traditional Catholic and Vodou prayers and blessings. The prèt savann is a Haitian innovation that arose after the Revolution when the Vatican ceased sending priests to the country. Prèt savanns filled the resulting religious vacuum, performing rituals that were previously the province of ordained Catholic priests.[8]

The prèt savann aiding in Zeta's wedding gained his religious knowledge in childhood, spending years as an altar boy at a Catholic Church.[9] Manbo Maude has worked with him for several years; he has officiated at some of her spiritual marriages and baptisms for newly initiated practitioners in her temple in Jacmel. Manbo Maude is capable of performing all the rituals the prèt savann carries out during weddings. She officiates at weddings in both Mattapan and Jacmel; however, she has more people to help in her role as a Manbo in Haiti and prefers to have a prèt savann officiate so she can focus on other religious responsibilities.

During the ceremony, the priest took off Zeta's ring and blessed it with Florida Water cologne, which participants used to cleanse ritual objects and bless participants and spirits during ceremonies. The scent of the cologne was also useful in attracting the spirits. To please Kouzen, the altar featured tobacco and food that had been prepared earlier in the day, including corn, avocados, bananas, and cassava. Because Zeta was marrying seven spirits, their food, alcohol, and ritual objects were also displayed on the altar. The priest asked Zeta and Kouzen if they wanted to take each other's hands in marriage. They both agreed. He presented them with a spiritual marriage contract, which stated the promise being made between the spirit and the practitioner, as well as the obligations they would need to fulfill as a part of their union. Both Zeta and Kouzen had to sign the contract. It included the signatures of two witnesses. The witnesses could be anyone who was a part of Zeta's spiritual home. After they signed the contract, they kissed each other on the cheek. Manbo Maude and her practitioners sang a song to usher Kouzen out of the ceremony and out of the body of the initiate he had mounted. As the initiate was recovering, Zeta left the temple to change into another outfit for the next spirit she would marry. When she returned to the temple, the process started anew.

Spiritual marriage, or mystical marriage, is a sacred institution that creates an allegiance between the practitioner and the spirits. It is a symbiotic

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relationship that establishes a ritual commitment; the spirit will aid the practitioner, and in turn, the practitioner will serve the spirits. The unions formed through spiritual marriage can be polyamorous, with people marrying multiple spirits and the spirits marrying multiple people. Scholarship on spiritual marriage is scant and largely explores basic ritual elements of the tradition.[10] Examining these rituals carefully and in more detail reveals that, through the mechanics of ritual, spiritual marriage is a way to connect spirit and practitioner and that this union is facilitated by fashion. In Manbo Maude's temples in Jacmel and Mattapan, establishing legitimate unions relies on the interconnectedness of the spirits, the practitioners, and the audience. Her traditions, however, do not represent the full spectrum of spiritual marriage in Vodou: rituals vary across temples and practitioners.

In chapter 2, I emphasize the role of labor in Manbo Maude's temples. Spiritual marriage affects the labor she is required to do in her religious community by relieving her of some of her responsibilities. As a Manbo, she is continually engaged in educating practitioners and initiates about Vodou and its many rituals. She provides guidance to the people in her home on both religious and personal matters by communicating with spirits through spiritual readings and other ritual services. When practitioners marry spirits, Manbo Maude no longer needs to function as a primary mediator, because members of her home can consult with the spirits directly, thereby reducing the *emotional labor* she performs. Practitioners "become more confident," Manbo Maude explained. "They don't have to consult with me all the time because the spirits start taking over. I have less work to do with the person."[11] Doing less work with her practitioners reduces not only her responsibilities but also her income. She usually charges for the spiritual readings and ritual work she does, but when practitioners communicate directly with the spirits more often, she loses this revenue. However, Manbo Maude is invested in facilitating the spiritual journeys of practitioners and initiates who are spiritually independent and confident in their abilities within Vodou. She maintains a commitment to passing on the knowledge of Vodou and its rituals and understands this to be a fundamental aspect of her role as a Manbo. Moreover, when she ushers members of her community into a more self-reliant relationship with the spirits, she can spend more time with newer members and with her own immediate family. Spiritual marriage facilitates ongoing exchanges of *emotional*, *intimate*, *aesthetic*, and *negotiatory labor* between practitioners and spirits.

The marital ritual performed in Vodou ceremonies combines African and Christian religious elements that include dancing, saluting the spirits, a reli-

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gious ritual contract, witnesses, and an officiator. It is a multisensorial practice involving the smell of food on the altar, the donning of clothes, the touch of hands and lips, and the rhythmic sound of ritual drums. Practitioners and spirits communicate directly as they make religious commitments to one another, and the audience and other initiates confer legitimacy of the union by acting as witnesses. Spiritual vogue exposes the ceremonial conventions of this practice, especially regarding the role of gender because of the expectations placed on women and their fashion and adornment choices. Ultimately, the ritual depends on the interconnectedness of the spirits, the practitioners, and the audience, which are tied together by devotional garments. When practitioners beautify their bodies, they wear the evidence of their meticulous efforts to please the spirits, proving their reverence for them and inviting them into the ceremony. The spirits' approval is clear when they land in a ceremony, reveling in their own exaltation, accepting rings at the altar, and committing to practitioners who have honored them. The religious fashion involved in spiritual marriage extends beyond ceremonies into the everyday lives of practitioners through the ongoing use of ritualized clothing and adornment, signaling a personal connection with the divine, aiding ongoing communication, and facilitating the crucial possibility of sexual contact between practitioners and spirits.

Sexual interactions, which happen *nan dòmi*, Haitian Kreyòl for "in dream," emphasize the commitment between practitioner and spirit and play a significant role in enabling intimate labor in spiritual marriage. Importantly, sex is not mandatory; whether to engage in it is a point of negotiation between the divine and their worshippers. These sexual relations cannot be reduced to mere tawdry affairs: they are expressions of care, pleasure, and adoration that reaffirm the affinity between spirits and practitioners, a sensual and ecstatic acknowledgment of the good work completed by the faithful *en sèvi*, Haitian Kreyòl for "in service" of the divine. Sexual encounters also occur outside spiritual marriages, often acting as an indicator of which spirits a practitioner has a special connection with. For the purposes of this chapter, however, I focus on how sex functions within ritual unions. Nan dòmi encounters are detached from the trifecta of spiritual vogue; they do not engage an audience. They are not public-facing ceremonies but private affairs defined by the intimate connections between spirits and their devotees.

As I made clear in previous chapters, the lwa meet practitioners where they are, and practitioners are resourceful and determined in their efforts to serve the divine. If they cannot have their needs met in one home, they often Vodou hop and search out another that can. In spiritual marriages,

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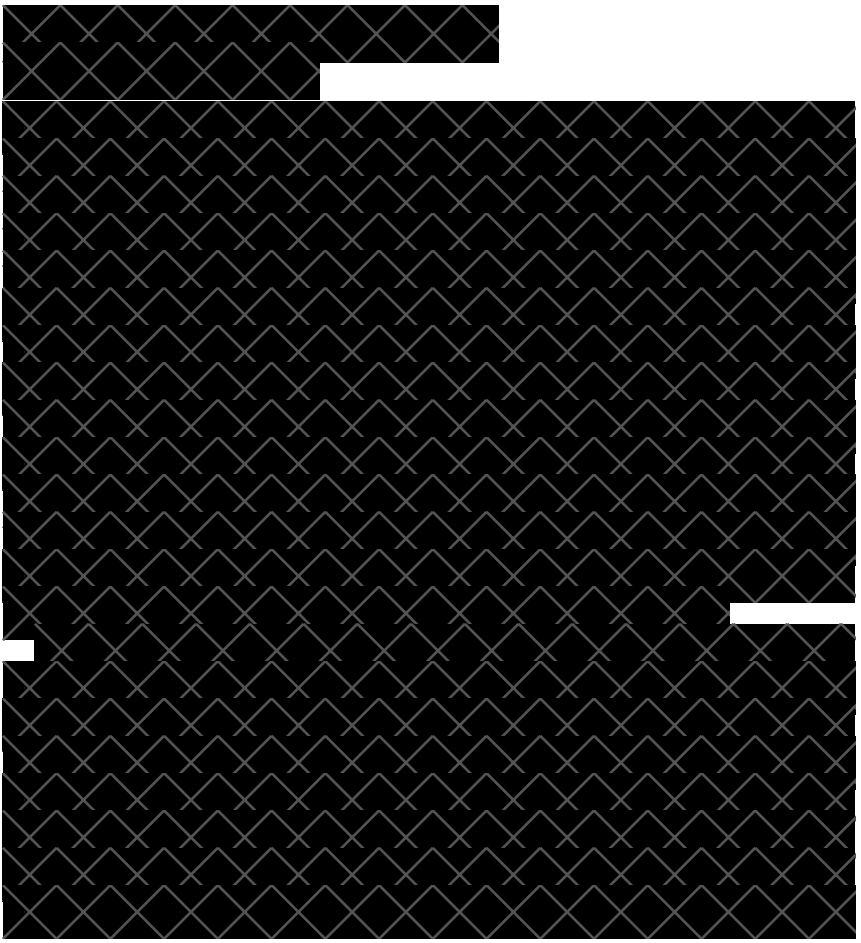
queer practitioners' quest for a temple with the capacity to satisfy them can be fruitless. Yet the lack of institutional support in the waking world does not foreclose queer people's ability to devote themselves to the spirits: it just pushes some unions into dreams. I argue that nan dòmi is a realm where the spirits can commune with queer practitioners who are unable to find a Manbo or Houngan willing to marry them because of their gender or sexuality to the deities for which they have an affinity. I contend that marriages nan dòmi illustrate the spirits' disregard for earthly prejudices about gender and sexuality and suggest the inherent queerness of lwa. These spiritual marriages, although not performed in a ceremony or presided over by a spiritual leader, are as consequential as any other. The bonds formed in dreams influence practitioners' daily existence, where they adorn themselves with clothing and jewelry that mark their commitment to the gods.



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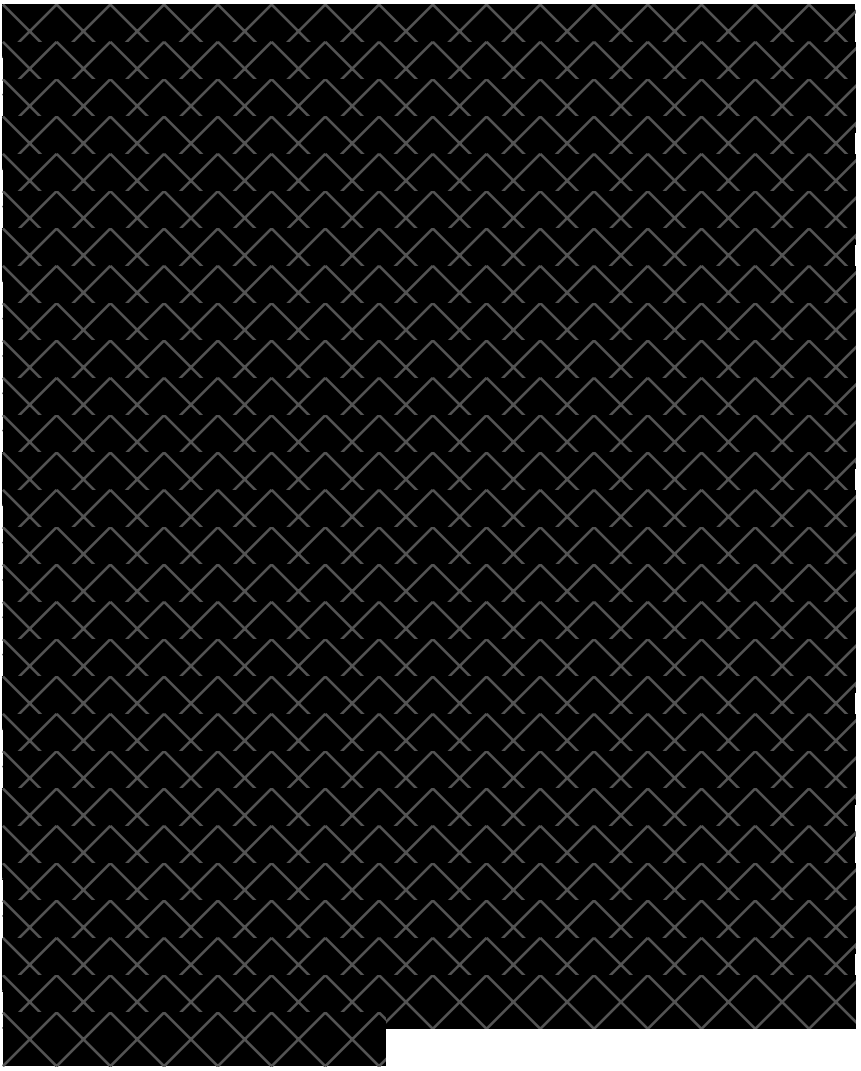

Ezili's Kisses: Consecrating Commitment on a Spiritual Wedding Day

Eddie was a twenty-seven-year-old cisgender, heterosexual native of Somerville, Massachusetts, when, in 2015, he decided to marry five spirits in Manbo Maude's temple in Jacmel. He was raised in a public housing project in Somerville and had been familiar with Vodou his whole life thanks to his Haitian parents, who were practitioners. His grandparents were also *Vodouizans*, practitioners of Vodou, as were their ancestors, stretching generations back in his family lineage. Although he grew up around the religion, it

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was not a meaningful part of his life until he was an adult, when he endured a nearly fatal experience. The event altered his perspective on his faith and his commitment to the spirits. When I first met Eddie in Jacmel, he was preparing for his marriage, and a week after we met, I was there to witness the ceremony. The spirits he remembered most vividly from the ceremony were the Ezilis: Ezili Freda, Ezili Dantò, and Metres Ezili. When we spoke years later in 2019 through WhatsApp, they were the marriages he described in the most detail. "There are others," Eddie explained. "But it's mainly the three."[23]

Several days before the marriage ceremony took place in Jacmel, Eddie underwent a ritual bath for good luck, while others planned a ritual designed to prepare him for the wedding and to rid him of any negative energy. Members of Manbo Maude's home brought a half-dozen hens into the temple and tied a small string to their legs, attaching them to nearby chairs so they could not escape the room. The hens needed to stay in the temple for a few days and nights, and they clucked and crowed the entire time. The time they spent in the temple made them holy, designating them as animals to be used in ritual services and showcasing them for the spirits. Sacred foods, rum, ritual objects, and elaborate fabrics were also placed on the altar in the temple. In the afternoon before the marriage, Manbo Maude performed a preparatory ceremony. She and all her practitioners wore simple white clothes. During this ceremony, the hens were moved by practitioners into the open-air area adjacent to the temple, rubbed with water that had been mixed with sacred herbs and leaves, and fed cornmeal.

Haitian female initiates cleansed Eddie with the hens by wiping them against his body and making circular motions above his head and feet. When the hens flapped their wings, they rid him of negative energy. The more they flapped their wings, the more negative energy escaped. During this ritual, two Haitian men tied a massive pig to the *potomitan*, or sacred center pole, in the center of the outside area and cleansed it with the sacred herbs and leaves. Previously, the pig had been tied to the sacred Mapou tree for two days, which made it holy. After the pig was brought into the temple, Ezili Dantò was called into the afternoon ceremony by practitioners. She possessed several female practitioners, including Manbo Maude and Eddie's mother. Red and blue moushwa were tied around their arms, head, and waists to signal Dantò's presence. Mounted practitioners rode the pig to show Dantò's acceptance of and appreciation for it. While possessed by Dantò, Manbo Maude was handed a da er and mimed stabbin herself and the air around her.

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In his dreams, Eddie was living in his home with his wives as the center of their affection and sexual desire. He described the three spirits fighting over him and vying for his affection. The playful interactions connoted a relationship built on mutual affection and respect. He was honoring them properly and therefore maintained their affection.

Before his spiritual marriage, Eddie used to have spiritual readings with Manbo Maude once a month. After the marriage, he only visited Manbo Maude for spiritual readings once a year. He credited this change to his stronger relationship to the spirits and the confidence he gained after marrying them. Eddie also understood his marriage to the spirits as preparation for marrying a human woman, saying, "They've helped me because I used to doubt if I could commit to a woman if I really get married."[37] He views the commitment he made to the spirits as an opportunity to learn lessons about himself and how he relates to other people, particularly women. "Now, if I found a woman that I truly love I can be dedicated and not cheat on her," he explained. "I know what's expected. [Spiritual marriage] teaches you self-discipline."[38] His dedication to the Ezilis and his resulting willingness to stay faithful to them prove that he can dedicate himself to a woman in the physical world.

When the Spirit Cums: Consummating Divine Intimacies in *Nan Dòmi*

Dreams are an inescapable and crucial aspect of Vodou.[39] They play a significant role in spiritual marriage by conveying messages and consummating the marital commitment. This dream state is often referred to as nan dòmi, the lucid dream state between conscious and unconscious where spirits connect with practitioners.[40] The messages received in dreams can be abstract, in which case the practitioner must decipher the meaning, or they can be quite literal, conveying clear messages from the spirits. In either case, these dreams are often shared within a practitioner's religious community where a spiritual guide or family member can help decode the messages to determine how best to please the spirits. Sometimes the dreams and messages are kept private: a practitioner might understand the messages without help or choose to find meaning through his or her own analysis. Thus, dreams, like possessions, can be interpersonal and intrapersonal experiences within a spiritual community. The lucid nature of nan dòmi explains why practitioners can recall their dreams in such vivid detail and

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why the decisions they make in the dreams regarding their relationships to spirits hold sway over their actions in the conscious world.

The dream world is held in high esteem because it is one of the avenues used to converse with the spirits and to negotiate with the divine. Fashion and adornment, either in nan dòmi or in preparation for it, fosters communicative relationships between practitioners and spirits, opening a space for the negotiation and reaffirmation of commitment. Nan dòmi is not only a space to learn about the unknown but is also where practitioners discern the desires of the spirits, respond to demands for material offerings, make commitments, and experience real, multisensorial contact with the divine. Away from the crowd and noise of the ceremonies, the spiritual encounters nan dòmi are not defined by the presence of a broader community of witnesses. Dreams offer an intimate space of connection between practitioners and spirits, often providing an opportunity for the sexual expression of marital commitment.

Eddie invited the spirits to communicate with him nan dòmi by dressing and bathing for the ones he married before going to sleep. Eddie, as well as other practitioners, dons specific clothing or colors for sleeping in anticipation of sexual encounters with certain spirits, which foster a continued devotion to and communication with the spirits. For Eddie, these dreams were a visceral, pleasurable experience that remained vivid on awakening: "I actually had a full wet dream. . . . It was crazy. And a couple nights ago, I actually, I almost had the same thing happen, but it was almost like I woke up and I was like, 'What the fuck am I doing?' Like I was humping the shit outta this bed. But it felt so real. There were times that it feels like I was with this person."[41] I asked Eddie how he knew which spirit he was having sex with, and he explained that he knew through their physical appearance. When he saw a woman with a dagger, he interpreted it to be Ezili Dantò because the dagger is a symbol commonly associated with her. A light-skinned woman, in contrast, represented Ezili Freda, who is often depicted as having fair skin.[42] Moreover, if two women appeared together and they were bickering, then they were the Ezilis, who have a contentious relationship as sisters. The Ezilis can be interpreted as sisters because they are part of the same family of spirits.

The sexual encounters like the one Eddie described are one key outcome of spiritual marriage. Although sex with spirits is not reserved only for those who marry the divine, it is commonly expected and helps curry continued favor from the spirits. Yet, it is not a mandatory obligation for initiates who marry; the spirits can communicate through numerous avenues. But for those who do engage in sex with the deities, that experience reaffirms their connection to the divine and can bring good fortune. Manbo Maude de-

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scribed the significance of sexual relationships with spirits as being an exchange of energy and compared it to sex with human partners. Sex with anyone, human or spirit, is "divine," Manbo Maude professed. "Your body is your temple. . . . It's spiritual when you have relationships with people."[43] Spirits and initiates give and take energy from one another during these experiences.

Eddie refrained from having sex with nonspiritual partners or himself on Tuesdays and Thursdays, the days reserved for the Ezilis. He would wait until sunrise on the following day to even think about having sex, after being scolded by the Ezilis nan dòmi in the past for having sex too soon after their special days ended. Engaging in sex almost immediately after midnight, when the day was technically done, was viewed as disrespectful by the deities, who felt slighted by his rush to leave them.[44] The fashion Eddie donned to honor the spirits, wearing white or the color associated with the spirits he married, as well as his rings, enabled this multisensorial sexual encounter nan dòmi. For Eddie, this fashion and adornment were part of the ongoing ritual work of spiritual marriage and a necessary aspect of communicating with the spirits. Eddie was able to touch, see, and hear the spirits. The adornment and fashion choices practitioners make to prepare their bodies facilitates a multisensorial sexual interaction that reinforces their faith and their surety that the spirits are a tangible presence in their everyday lives.

Though Manbo Maude emphasized the importance of heteronormative spiritual marriages, there are practitioners who have affinities for same-gender spirits and have sexual relationships with them as well, inside and outside her spiritual home. In Manbo Maude's spiritual homes and in many other Vodou temples, the gender conventions on display during spiritual marriages are often explained as based on tradition, but there are also cultural and societal reasons for these ritual preferences. When I interviewed a Houngan and scholar of Haitian studies whom I call Joel, he argued that the widespread reluctance to embrace same-gender spiritual marriages in Vodou was rooted in homophobia in Haiti: "People would be horrified if we had a ceremony, and I was going to marry Ogou Ferray and Ogou Badagri. People would be very offended. A Haitian would be very offended because they are homophobic. . . . I blame Christianity for that. Because this is where they learn to discriminate against homosexuals."[45] Joel described homophobia as being widespread, yet some temples embrace same-gender marriages. In Jacmel, there are Vodou homes that allow same-gender spiritual marriage and permit transgender people to marry according to their gender identity. In 2018, I Vodou hopped to a spiritual home that was run

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by a gay Haitian man who had spiritually married initiates and spirits of the same gender. Although I did not witness these ceremonies, I was told about them by Manbo Maude and by initiates in her home. Spiritual marriages are mostly officiated publicly during ceremonies, but Joel asserted that his marriage to Ogou and the Ezilis happened in the dream state.

Finding practitioners willing to openly discuss sexual encounters with spirits is often difficult, including among practitioners in Manbo Maude's temples. In private, people shared the details of their sexual relationships with spirits but only with the expectation of complete secrecy. For that reason, I continue to share Joel's experience, even though he is not a member of Manbo Maude's religious communities. His story of sex, marriage, and the spirits offers a valuable point of contrast with some of the traditions stipulated by Manbo Maude and emphasizes the intimate connections between practitioners and the lwa. The interconnectedness of the spirits, practitioners, and audience is not required to establish a valid union. Barred from having his marriage recognized in many temples because of his and Ogou's gender, Joel relies on the bonds formed nan dòmi to reinforce his commitments. In dreams, the homosexuality of their relationship is a non-issue. The promises made nan dòmi carry into Joel's daily life, where he understands the marriage to be legitimate.

When I interviewed Joel over the phone, he described his sexual encounter with two versions of Ogou: Ogou Ferray and Ogou Badagri. He had a strong connection with Ogou, even though he had never formally committed to him during a public marriage ceremony. The sexual encounter was proof of their devotion to one another and of the tacit truth that spirits could have same-gender desires, as shown in this interview excerpt:

> JOEL: I am married to two Ogous as a matter of fact. As a matter of fact about fifteen years ago, I woke up about five o'clock in the morning, and I was covered with sperm and it was not my own. And I woke up and I went to a pile of CDs which I had never opened, that I had purchased and never played, went to the middle of that pile, pulled out a recording by a Haitian band. [I] put on my CD player, and here was a song that Ogou was singing to me in the dream. I have never heard that song before. . . . I went straight to that CD and played the song that they were singing to me.
>
> EZIAKU: So you woke up to sperm that wasn't yours?
>
> JOEL: No.
>
> EZIAKU: How did you know that it wasn't yours?

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JOEL: Because I know it was not mine, because I know mine.
EZIAKU: Because you know yours. Was the smell different?
JOEL: Yeah. And because I was making love all night to the two Ogous.
EZIAKU: Oh wow. So, the two Ogous, what did they look like? Were they dark-skinned, light-skinned?
JOEL: Well, it's interesting, when I see those Haitian spirits I see them as light brown. Typically light brown. He comes to me from time to time and he is light brown. Or medium brown and green eyes.
EZIAKU: And so, you had sex with the Ogou.
JOEL: It was *very* wonderful.[46]

During our interview, I repeated my questions because I wanted to make sure I understood the spiritual experience he was describing. His detailed description of his encounter with the two Ogous illustrates the intense, pleasurable sexual experiences that are possible nan dòmi. The residues of the dream are the evidence of spiritual presence, a mark left behind by the spirits to communicate their mutual affection and belonging. Joel also told me that Ogou gave him a ring as a gift during his dream to signify their commitment, another symbolic material offering signifying their union. In an earlier dream state, he had a wedding ceremony where he married Ezili Dantò and Ezili Freda and engaged in all the rituals that were described during Eddie's marriage. The Ezilis gave him rings to honor their commitment as well. In the waking world, Joel does not wear any rings for the deities on his fingers but considers the adornment that took place nan dòmi to be as fully binding as anything he might have done during a full ceremony in the presence of other practitioners. Because nan dòmi is a lucid dream state, he recognized the commitment he was making and the resulting consequences in the conscious world. In his home, he has altars dedicated to the spirits, and he sets aside days to honor them. He also wears colors dedicated to the spirits he serves. Joel places very little significance on the type of marriage ceremonies Manbo Maude performs for her initiates, instead emphasizing the direct connection between a practitioner and a spirit during the dream state. "I don't have to do it in a ritual and spend that kind of money,"[47] he concluded. His perspective on spiritual marriage and sex between practitioners and spirits provides an avenue through which to explore the reality of same-gender encounters. Nan dòmi, spirits can circumvent the heteronormative boundaries placed on them by temples in the physical realm.

Manbo Maude, like Joel, has an affinity for a same-gender spirit: Ezili Dantò. As previously mentioned, the Ezilis are some of the primary spirits

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who influence her innovative relationship to religious fashion. To honor her connection to Dantò, Manbo Maude wears a ring and specific dresses during ceremonies. Moreover, she has married male spirits who are affiliated with Dantò, such as Ogou and Simbi, a freshwater spirit and healer. "I married them to show her my commitment toward her men,"[48] Manbo Maude explained. "She won't be jealous that I am with her men. She will collaborate with me [because I am] taking care of her men." Thus, Manbo Maude's relationship to Dantò is mediated through her marriage to male spirits who represent this important connection through their affiliation with Dantò. When Manbo Maude said "her men," she was referencing larger ideas within the Vodou ethos that pair various spirits with one another in sexual or familial relationships. Dantò, for example, is said to have taken Ogou as a lover and given birth to his children, and she has also had a sexual relationship with Simbi. Instead of marrying Ezili Dantò directly, she wears a ring and married the male spirits associated with her. Ogou and Simbi are not substitutes or stand-ins for Dantò but represent the broader family of spirits she is dedicated to and who help her perform spiritual services. It is also possible that the rigidity of the marriage traditions in Manbo Maude's home necessitates this arrangement, that her connection to a female deity could only be ritualistically established through male spirits. Ultimately, the adornment practice of wearing a ring to show dedication to the spirits connects Manbo Maude to male and female deities whether she has married them or not, binding her to the spirits who have had the most impact on her life and religious communities.

When I spoke with Manbo Maude in 2016 about her connection to Ezili Dantò, she told me how she came to acquire a blue ritual dress that was made especially for the spirit. During a dream she had in the early days of her tenure as a Manbo, Dantò came to her and sexually propositioned her. Manbo Maude reacted defensively, forcibly shoving her away. After having that dream, several strange misfortunes befell Manbo Maude, and her spiritual mother advised her that the bad luck was the result of Dantò feeling disrespected. Her spiritual mother prescribed performing a series of rituals to regain Dantò's respect. Manbo Maude followed the instructions, and after performing the rituals, which included lighting a candle and saying a series of prayers, she encountered the deity in a second dream. Nan dòmi, Manbo Maude observed Ezili Dantò in a stream, engaging in sex with Ezili Freda. Dantò had both a penis and a vagina—a common, though not universal, description among the practitioners. Manbo Maude recalled the sexual encounter in great detail, describing the sight of ejaculate in the river. "I saw when she reached the climax," Manbo Maude said. She found the entire

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scene alarming and was frightened when Dantò looked to her for her next tryst. She wanted to flee but feared disrespecting Dantò a second time and so stood by the water, petrified.

When Dantò and Ezili Freda were done having sex, Dantò ascended from the water and approached Manbo Maude. The spirit spoke with compassion: "I know you are not that way, and I will not do those things to you, because I know you don't like it. I will never do that to you because I know you don't like that. But I need you to know that you are mine, and you belong to me, so wear this dress."[49] Dantò handed Manbo Maude a blue dress. When Manbo Maude awoke she remembered the dress and sought out fabrics that mirrored the appearance of the garment nan dòmi. She created an elegant blue dress for Dantò and immediately wore it for seven days. Later, she donned the same outfit during a ceremony dedicated to the spirit. "She never came onto me that way again," Manbo Maude recalled. "I was blessed after that, and I stopped having problems."[50]

As previously discussed, sex is a common means through which the spirits communicate with those devoted to them. Although Manbo Maude was not married to Ezili Dantò, the offer of sex represented a possible avenue of connection and favor. When Manbo Maude indicated that she was not interested in sex, Dantò shifted to fashion as another means of communication. The dress symbolized the nonsexual relationship between Dantò and Manbo Maude while still indicating their dedication to one another. This encounter illustrates the ongoing negotiation between spirits and practitioners nan dòmi and the importance of fashion as a conduit for such conciliation. The negotiatory labor necessitated by Manbo Maude's encounters with Dantò nan dòmi allowed the two to find a mutually beneficial relationship. Though Manbo Maude was unwilling to engage in sex with Dantò, she accepted the compromise, creating in the real world the dress Dantò demanded in the dream, thereby solidifying their connection. This compromise was also reached through the emotional labor Manbo Maude engaged in, negotiating with Dantò face-to-face in her dreams.[51] She needed to mediate the tension between herself and the deity to stay in Dantò's favor and avoid the bad luck associated with disobeying a spirit. For Manbo Maude and Dantò, clothing marked their mutual affection and commitment. The decision to make a dress nan dòmi had real consequences in Manbo Maude's religious practices, just as the rings offered to Joel in his dream established real-world connections with the spirits.

The spiritual dreams that Manbo Maude, Eddie, and Joel recounted were defined not only by a sense of intense intimacy. Within their stories lie a clear

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attempt by the gods to claim them as devoted supplicants through sex and adornment. Both the deities and the practitioners demonstrate a belief in mutual belonging, articulated through ritual items like rings and clothing and meetings nan dòmi. Within ceremonies, possessions allow for various gendered expressions to occur, yet women are clearly afforded a wider array of masculine and feminine expressions of the divine, as well as nonbinary manifestations. As a result of the social confines that permeate religious rituals, and often in contradiction of the nature of the divine, the possession performances of male practitioners are limited. I argue that cisgender heterosexual men are prevented from obtaining a fuller connection to the divine because they have to operate within patriarchal expectations. Negotiations with restrictive social mores curb the full expression of Vodou and the potential egalitarianism of ceremonies such as spiritual marriages. Although Manbo Maude and members of her temples have pushed some gender boundaries, they also invest in gender norms in their ritual practice. This contradiction is embodied in young practitioners who are continuously pushing the borders of beliefs, challenging and maintaining the status quo. Manbo Maude's daughter is a part of the next generation of Vodou practitioners who will determine how the faith interprets its traditions. The following chapter explores the intergenerational nature of Vodou with Vante'm Pa Fyem at the forefront, shaping her own relationship to fashion and adornment. Like her mother, Vante'm Pa Fyem has a unique connection with the spirits and maintains the legacy started by Manbo Maude while beginning to cultivate her own stylistic tastes in service of the divine.

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